

# Start here

*Never used an AI? Begin with this.*

Created by Hans Tandt · Version 1.0 · September 2026

This short guide is for you if you have never used an AI tool. In ten minutes you will have your first real conversation with Claude. You need no paid plan and no technical knowledge.

## What you need

- A computer or phone with internet.
- An email address you will keep.
- Ten quiet minutes.

### Use an email you will keep

Claude ties your account and history to your email. You cannot change it later. Use a personal address, not a work or school one.

## Your first conversation

This works on the **free plan**, in any web browser.

1. Open **claude.ai** in your browser.
2. Create a free account with your email.
3. Type the prompt below and press Enter.
4. Answer Claude's questions in your own words.
5. Ask for a change: **"Make it shorter and simpler."**

### Copy this prompt

I have never used an AI before. Ask me three short questions about my work. Then suggest one small task you could help me with today.

### That is the whole idea

You ask. Claude answers. You steer. You never start over; you correct.

### Claude changes fast

This guide reflects September 2026. If a screen looks different, trust the app.

All guides, free, in English, French, Dutch and German: **[hans-tandt.github.io/AI-Guides](https://hans-tandt.github.io/AI-Guides)**

## Eight words you will meet

| Word      | In plain words                                                                       |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Prompt    | What you type to Claude. Your question or request.                                   |
| Chat      | A conversation with Claude, like messaging a person.                                 |
| Model     | The "engine" that does the thinking. Smarter models use more of your allowance.      |
| Context   | Everything Claude can see while it answers: your messages and files.                 |
| Token     | A small piece of text, about three-quarters of a word. Limits are counted in tokens. |
| Cowork    | Claude on your PC, working on the files in one folder. Needs a paid plan.            |
| Sandbox   | A temporary, closed-off computer where Claude runs its work. Wiped at the end.       |
| Connector | A link that lets Claude reach another app, like your mail or calendar.               |

## Three habits from day one

1. **Let Claude ask first.** End a request with: "Ask me questions first."
2. **Check what it says.** Claude sounds just as sure when it is wrong. Check anything important against a reliable source.
3. **Protect your data.** Think before you paste. Some things never belong in a chat.

### Your text leaves your computer

Everything you type is processed on Anthropic's servers. Never paste passwords, bank details or other people's personal data.

The one-page **AI Data Rules** show what is safe to share.

## What to read next

|   | Guide                  | Read it when...                                                      |
|---|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Level Zero · Beginner  | You want Claude to work on your own files. Cowork needs a paid plan. |
| 2 | What an AI actually is | You have used Claude for a week and want to know what it really is.  |
| 3 | Level One              | The basics feel easy and you want to build real things.              |
| + | AI Data Rules          | Now. Print it and keep it next to your screen.                       |